

Where was MH370 at 00:19 UTC?

A reproduction of the DSTG Bayesian aircraft-position pdf (Davey et al. 2016, Fig. 10.3)

Base estimate: no hypotheses enabled.

This report recreates the probability density function (pdf) of the aircraft's latitude at the final satellite handshake, 00:19 UTC on 8 March 2014, from the model published by Davey, Gordon, Holland, Rutten and Williams, *Bayesian Methods in the Search for MH370* (Springer, 2016). The aircraft state is filtered from the penultimate radar point at 18:01:49 UTC through all Inmarsat burst timing (BTO) and burst frequency (BFO) measurements, using the published cruise, manoeuvre and measurement models.

With BTO and BFO the recreated pdf has median 38.23°S and mode 38.60°S, with 95% of probability between 35.86°S and 39.69°S. The published curve has median 37.53°S, mode 37.90°S and 95% range 34.90–39.38°S. The two densities overlap by 71%. This curve is centred 0.7° further south and carries 4% of probability in the published northern shoulder between 34.5°S and 36.5°S (25% in the book). The difference persists at every particle count tried, so it reflects inputs the book does not publish (ACCESS-G weather, the numerical radar prior, autopilot-mode weights) rather than sampling noise. Without BFO the pdf is bimodal: 7% of probability lies in a narrow northern mode centred at 44.7°N, matching the narrow mode near 45°N in the book's BTO-only panel (read from the figure, not digitised). The BFO removes the northern mode, as reported by Davey et al.

Relative to the base estimate, the median moves 0.07° south, the 34.5–36.5°S shoulder holds 4% of probability (base 4%), and the two curves overlap by 95%.

The curve pools 4 independent replicates of 7,000,000 particles. Single replicates overlap each other by 87%–90% and their medians span 0.19°. Pooling half of the replicates against the other half gives 92% overlap, so the pooled curve does not depend materially on the random seed.

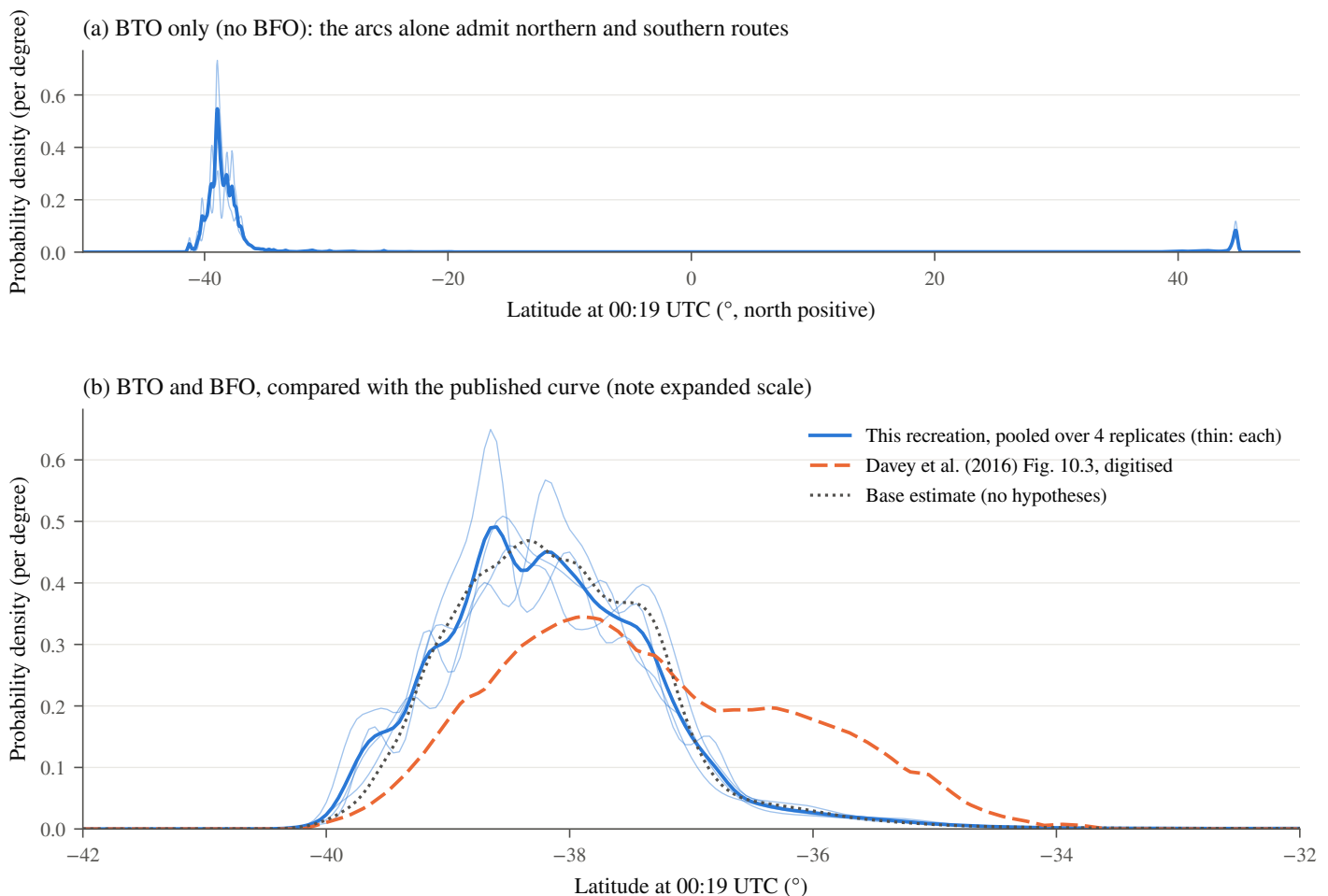


Figure 1. Latitude pdf of the aircraft at 00:19:37 UTC, the form of Davey et al. Fig. 10.3. (a) BTO only. (b) BTO and BFO, with the published curve. Densities are weighted particle histograms smoothed with a 0.1° Gaussian; each particle carries its own altitude. Evidence: BTO at every epoch except the 18:39 and 23:15 C-channel calls; BFO (bottom only) at 18:28, 18:39, 19:41–22:41, 23:15 and 00:11. No fuel, debris, drift, search or end-of-flight evidence is used. Base estimate: no hypotheses enabled.

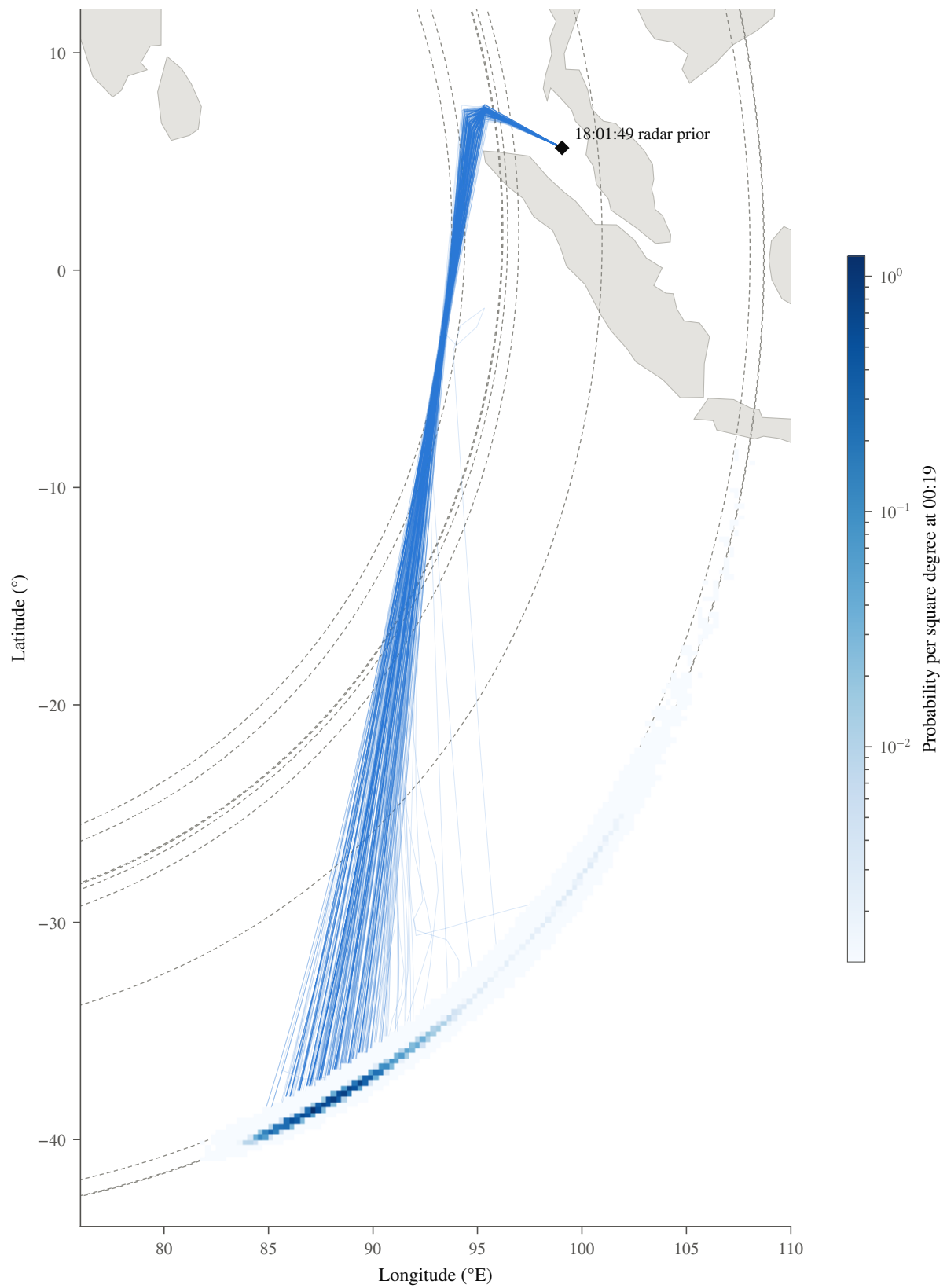
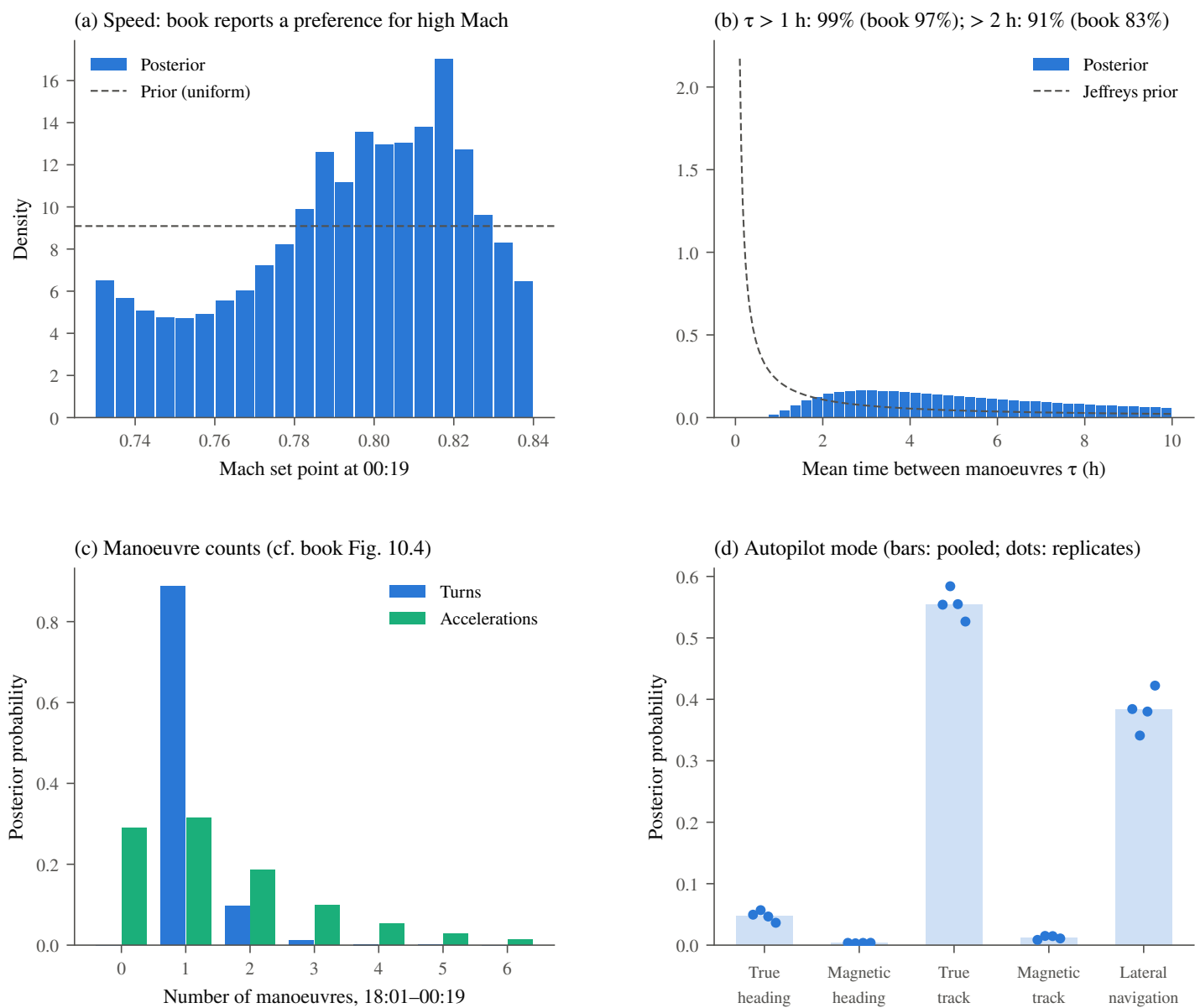


Figure 2. Posterior aircraft position at 00:19 UTC with BTO and BFO, pooled over 4 replicates (blue shading, logarithmic), and 400 routes drawn in proportion to posterior weight from replicate seed 1 (thin lines, 10-minute vertices). Dashed grey curves are the BTO arcs at a reference altitude of 35,000 ft; they are drawn for orientation only. Land: Natural Earth 1:110m.

Posterior behaviour compared with the book



	This recreation	Davey et al. (2016)
Median latitude	38.23°S	37.53°S
Mode	38.60°S	37.90°S
95% interval	35.86–39.69°S	34.90–39.38°S
95% width	3.84°	4.47°
Overlap with published pdf	71% (replicates 69%–73%)	—
Median Mach at 00:19	0.798	upper part of 0.73–0.84
P(north of equator), BTO only	7%	northern mode present

Figure 3 and Table 1. Posterior summaries with BTO and BFO, pooled over replicates, alongside the statements in Davey et al. (2016), sec. 10.2–10.4. Book values of the latitude pdf come from the digitised Fig. 10.3 (bottom); other book values are quoted from the text.

Method, convergence and reproduction

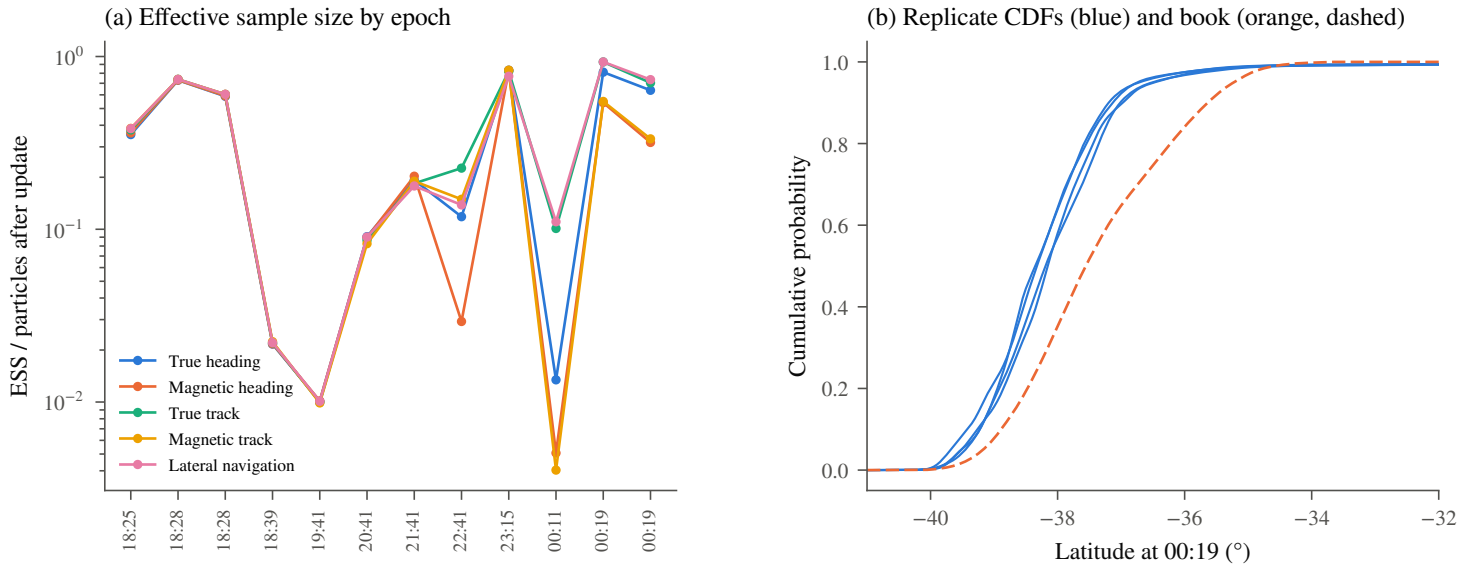


Figure 4. (a) Effective sample size after each measurement update, averaged over replicates, per autopilot-mode filter. The narrowest bottlenecks are the 18:39 C-channel BFO (the southward turn) and the 19:41 BTO arc. (b) Latitude CDFs of the 4 independent replicates; the largest difference between any two is 0.112 (Kolmogorov distance).

Model. The state, dynamics and likelihood follow Davey et al. (2016) chapters 4–8: prior at 18:01:49 UTC with 0.5 NM position and 1° track uncertainty, Mach uniform on 0.73–0.84, altitude on 1,000 ft levels from 25,000 to 43,000 ft; five autopilot modes (true/magnetic heading, true/magnetic track, lateral navigation with a one-off reversion to heading hold); Ornstein–Uhlenbeck fluctuations of Mach, control angle and wind error with the published rates; turns, speed changes and climbs arriving with exponential gaps of common mean τ (Jeffreys prior on 0.1–10 h) at 15° bank, 0.1 Mach per minute and 4,000 ft per minute. BTO is Gaussian with the tabulated per-message errors (29, 43 or 63 μ s); BFO has 7 Hz noise and an unknown constant bias (prior 150 ± 25 Hz) marginalised exactly per particle with a Kalman filter.

Substitutions. The book's ACCESS-G weather is replaced by ERA5 winds and temperatures; magnetic declination is IGRF-14. The prior mean position and track are reconstructed from the book's radar figures because they are not tabulated. Davey et al. used variable-rate branching; this recreation uses fixed-size particle filters with systematic resampling when ESS falls below 50% of the particles. The book warns that conventional resampling collapses static parameters (sec. 10.4). Both are therefore handled exactly: one filter per autopilot mode, combined in proportion to its estimated marginal likelihood, and a Gibbs refresh of τ from its path conditional after every resampling step. Without them, a plain bootstrap filter of one million particles retained only about one hundred distinct prior draws, and an earlier recreation in this project found tails and turn counts that changed with the random seed.

Run. Configuration fnl; particles per mode 1,000,000, 500,000, 2,500,000, 500,000, 2,500,000 (order as in Figure 3d), 7,000,000 per replicate; BTO+BFO seeds 1, 2, 3, 4; BTO-only seeds 1, 2; code revision 41ab50b-dirty; 18 threads; total runtime 26.7 min; peak memory 6,954 MiB. Base estimate: no hypotheses enabled.

Reproduce with one command from the repository root: make report

Parameters and model choices against Davey et al. (2016)

41 parameters and choices. 32 match the published model; 9 differ and are marked. A difference is not by itself a defect: some are deliberate and documented (ERA5 for the unavailable ACCESS-G, IGRF-14 for NOAA, the sampler), some are the subject of the run (a widened Mach range), and some are worth fixing. Page numbers refer to the book; the full table with citations and notes is written beside this report as parameters.csv.

Parameter	This run	Davey et al. (2016)
Dynamics		
Mach OU reversion rate (1/s)	0.01058	0.01058
Mach OU noise strength (1/s)	2.05e-07	2.05e-07
Control-angle OU reversion rate (1/s)	0.009792	0.009792
Control-angle OU noise strength (rad ² /s)	4.074e-08	4.074e-08
Wind-error OU reversion rate (1/s)	0.001087	0.001087
Wind-error OU noise strength (kn ² /s)	0.07021	0.07021
Manoeuvre time constant, Jeffreys support (h)	[0.1, 10]	[0.1, 10]
Mach after an acceleration, uniform on (Mach)	[0.73, 0.84]	[0.73, 0.84]
Altitude after a vertical manoeuvre, uniform on (ft)	[25000, 43000]	[25000, 43000]
Altitude step (ft)	1000	1000
Bank angle in turns (deg)	15	15
Mach rate during an acceleration (Mach/s)	0.00166667	0.00166667
Vertical rate during a climb or descent (ft/s)	66.6667	66.6667
Mean time to lateral-navigation reversion (s)	31162.2	31162.2
Cruise integration step (s)	10	10
▶ Manoeuvre integration step (s)	5	1
Prior		
Prior epoch (UTC)	2014-03-07T18:01:49Z	2014-03-07T18:01:49Z
▶ Position standard deviation (NM)	0.5	0.4
Track standard deviation (deg)	1	1
BFO bias prior mean (Hz)	150	150
BFO bias prior standard deviation (Hz)	25	25
▶ Initial Mach set point	-	[0.82, 0.03]
▶ Prior mean position and track	-	not tabulated
Autopilot-mode prior weights	[[true heading, 1], [magnetic heading,...	equal over the five modes
Measurement		
BTO fixed offset (us)	495679	495679
BTO noise sd, R1200 (us)	29 at 7 epochs	29
BTO noise sd, anomalous R1200 (us)	43 at 2 epochs	43
▶ BTO noise sd, R600 (us)	63 at 1 epoch	62
BFO noise sd (Hz)	7 at 11 epochs	7
BFO bias treatment	constant per trajectory, Kalman-margina...	constant per trajectory, Kalman-marginalised
BTO bias treatment	-	fixed per-flight T_channel only; no bias st...
Vertical rate in the BFO model	-	not modelled
00:19 BFO	-	not used; believed unreliable
Model choice		
▶ Weather source	config/sensitivity/./../data/fnl-wind-...	ACCESS-G, 150-500 hPa (about 18,000-44,000...
▶ Magnetic declination source	config/./data/igrf14-declination.bin	NOAA
▶ Resampling scheme	one filter per autopilot mode combined...	randomised branching: weight >= eta branche...
Manoeuvre-type dependence	-	turns, accelerations and vertical manoeuvre...
Turn extent (deg)	-	uniform on -180 to +180
▶ Cost-index speed mode	-	implemented but unused in most experiments;...
Fuel and endurance	-	infinite fuel; constraints applied to the p...
Observation cutoff	m0019b	00:19 (BTO only at 00:19)

▶ marks a difference. Rows whose value is prose or a file identifier cannot be compared by string match; for those the reference file asserts the relationship explicitly and parameters.csv records why. Quantities held per epoch rather than per run — the BTO and BFO measurement standard deviations — are in data/satcom-observations.csv and are compared in the note column of the CSV.